

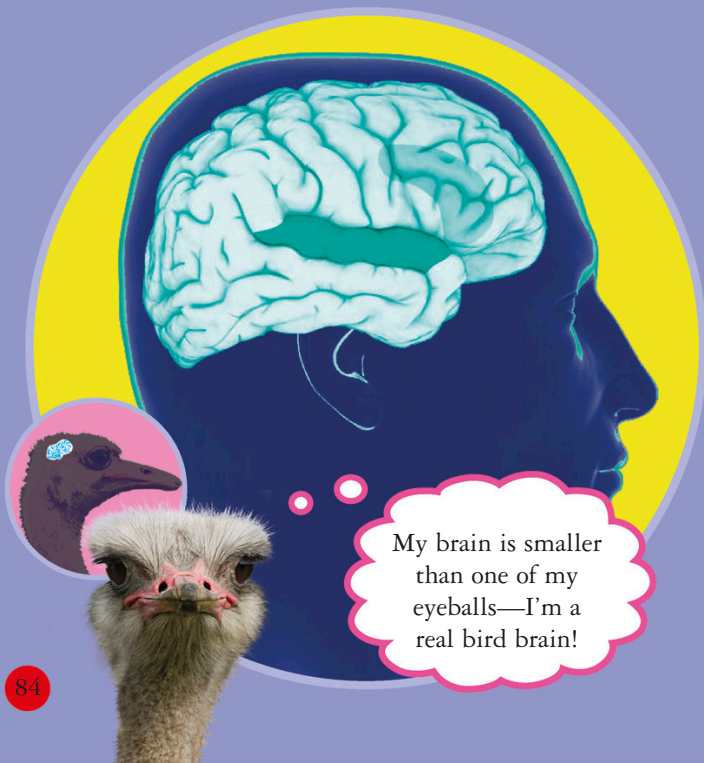


The **ULTIMATE** *animal?*

HUMANS are **just like** any other *animal*—we all need **oxygen** to *breathe*, *water* to drink, and *food* to provide energy. However, over thousands of years humans have evolved a unique set of **skills** and abilities that enable us to overcome some of the many difficulties that every organism faces in the struggle to survive.

Brain power

One of our greatest assets is the human brain, which is large for our body size and highly developed. Unlike many other animals we are self-aware, can solve problems, have language, and can make tools. We are not alone in these abilities—apes, elephants, and dolphins can all recognize themselves in mirrors, use tools, and communicate. Like us, these animals have spindle neurons (very large brain cells) that allow rapid communication across the brain. These play a key role in the development of intelligent behavior.



My brain is smaller than one of my eyeballs—I'm a real bird brain!

Social intelligence

Humans are not necessarily cleverer than other organisms. What we do possess is the ability to create and learn and turn that into a cultural knowledge that we share with others. When you play with your friends and go to school you are acquiring this knowledge and culture. If only one human knew everything, humans would not last long as a species. Dolphins, chimps, and elephants also pass on skills such as making and using tools to catch food, which suggests that they too have a simple form of culture.

